

Designing for the Social Good

Course Summary - Unit 2, Module 1 - Instructor: Josh Harvey

Summary prepared from 5 lecture decks (Design-Practice repo)

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Lecture 1 - Surprise! We're Not Talking About ICT4D (12 Feb)

Sets the theoretical foundation by tracing where "development" ideology comes from and what assumptions it smuggles in.

Classical development theory (critiqued)

- Weber: rationalization, bureaucratic capacity, rule-based governance as the ideal.
- Parsons: structural functionalism - modernization = differentiation of roles/institutions; traditional societies framed as less adaptive.
- Rostow: five universal stages of growth; progress = capital accumulation, industrialization.

High Modernism vs. Post-Development

- High Modernism: scientific ways of knowing, anthropocentric, hegemonic, capitalist consumption, atomized/individualist, ahistorical, "apolitical."
- Post-Development (the emerging alternative): alternate worldviews, holistic, pluriversal, degrowth, relational, collectivist, contextualized, situated and political.

Techne vs. Metis

- Techne: formal, codified, systematic knowledge oriented toward technical control and replicable production; operates and scales through legibility.
- Metis: contextual, experiential, embodied practical intelligence developed through lived engagement; the capacity to navigate complex systems.

Sociotechnical systems & ICT4D

- Latour: society and technology are not ontologically distinct - artifacts are designed to constrain/shape human action (we "delegate" duties and values to technologies).
- Sociotechnical system: complex system involving interactions between humans, technology, and environment.
- ICT4D = the design of interventions in complex sociotechnical (ecological) systems in service of social transformation.
- Cynefin framework (Snowden): navigating complexity requires probing, sensing, and responding.

Closing thesis: "Design centers people... but thinks in systems... Design shifts frames." Assignment 1: write 7500 words on how high-modernist values / a preoccupation with techne manifest in international development and humanitarian work, using concrete examples.

Lecture 2 - What's Design? Which Design? Whose Design? (16 Feb)

First portion reviews Lecture 1. New content explores what "design" means across disciplines and introduces the core design process used for the rest of the course.

Definitions of design (compiled from multiple sources)

- Design Council: "what happens when people use creativity to solve problems."
- Chapman: "making things to serve a useful goal."
- Rodgers & Bremner: a historic project to imagine change and answer "what kind of world do we really want to live in?"
- Papanek: design is the conscious effort to impose meaningful order - as much cleaning a drawer or educating a child as composing a poem.

Design disciplines by complexity (Di Russo, 2014)

- Artefact (low complexity): product, fashion, interior, graphic, web, engineering.
- Artefact & Experience: interaction design, HCI, human-centered design, UX, anthropological design.
- Systems & Behaviour: urban planning, architecture, service design, strategic design, culture.
- Large-Scale Systems (high complexity): policy design, systems design, environment, public service, global contexts.

Service design

- Mager: "the activity of choreographing people, infrastructure, communication, and material components of a service to create value for the multiple stakeholders involved."
- Components: People (user, provider), Props (material/digital elements), Processes (rules, procedures, methods) - value is co-created (the "offering").

Design Tracks spectrum (Irwin, Kossoff, Tonkinwise)

Built World (products/comms/environments) -> Design for Service -> Design for Social Innovation -> Transition Design -> Natural World. "Design for interactions" spans the whole spectrum; Transition Design specifically = an approach for effecting long-term transformation at scale of complex socio-technical-ecological systems.

The core design process (introduced here, used throughout the course)

- Five stages: Sensing -> Sensemaking -> Stating our Point of View -> Imagining Alternatives -> Transforming & Integrating.
- Design is a circular process; iteration is foundational - problems and solutions co-evolve.
- Design follows a pattern of divergence and convergence at each stage (double-diamond structure).
- Solutions are evaluated on three overlapping criteria: Desirability, Feasibility, Viability.

Lecture 3 - Sensing (19 Feb)

The deepest methods lecture: how designers gather ("sense") and then structure ("sensemake") information from the field.

Design research

- Research FOR design: research that enables/informs design.
- Research THROUGH design: "a design activity that operates as research" (Forlizzi & Zimmerman) - surfaces and embeds insight into artefacts as "instantiations of understanding" / embodiments of possible futures.

- Research spans a Generative <-> Evaluative spectrum.

Ethnographic methods (interview & observation are the core)

- The ABC model: Attitudinal (thoughts/feelings), Behavioural (observable actions), Contextual (conditions influencing both).
- Ethnographic interviews: not a survey; a dialogue focused on informants' lived experience; semi/unstructured, 20-60 min, in context.
- Descriptive question types: Grand Tour (typical/specific/guided/task-related), Mini-Tour, Example, Experience, Native Language questions.
- Other question types: Structural (how informants understand/categorize) and Contrast (meaning-making, e.g. "what's the difference between a slide and an activity?").
- Additional methods: card sort, semantic differential, diad/triad interviews, contextual inquiry, diary study, cultural probe.
- Focus groups are explicitly discouraged (marked with a "no" symbol in the deck).
- Capturing data: "Always Be Capturing"; interviews are primary, observations contextual; follow the verbatim principle; stay aware of bias/interpretation; capture Place/Actors/Activities.

Sensemaking - "structuring the unknown so as to be able to act on it" (Waterman)

- Four activities: Organize Findings -> Find Themes -> Identify Insights -> Create Frames.
- Organizing by affinity (affinity diagramming) is one common approach.
- Sensemaking artefacts: empathy maps, personas, experience maps, customer journey maps, service blueprints, causal loop diagrams, iceberg diagrams (Event -> Patterns -> Structures -> Mental Models).
- A theme = a pattern relating to actors' behaviours/experiences and the needs/motivations expressed through them.
- Coding: colour-coding interview transcripts against a defined scheme to surface patterns.
- A good insight is: (1) well-informed by multiple data points, (2) more than an observation - offers a compelling reframe, (3) answers "so what?" and connects to project impact.
- Insights split into Design Opportunities (generative) and Design Principles/Constraints (evaluative).
- Frames are thinking tools/lenses for interpreting the problem space, following the format: "If the problem situation is approached as if it is..., then...."

Lecture 4 - Sensemaking Recap (19 Feb, continued)

This session is essentially a full repeat/consolidation of Lecture 3's Sensemaking material (same slides on affinity diagramming, empathy maps, personas, journey maps, service blueprints, causal loops, iceberg diagrams, themes/insights/frames) - no significant new content.

Lecture 5 - Point of View (23 Feb)

Covers how to synthesize research into an actionable problem statement, and how to translate that into ideation prompts.

Point of View (POV) statement

- Also called a problem statement or design brief; synthesizes conclusions vis-a-vis the context, frame, and specific problems/opportunities within that frame.
- Format: "[Actor] needs to [Need] because [Insight]."

- Worked example: "A harried mother of three, rushing through the airport only to wait hours at the gate, needs to entertain her playful children because 'annoying little brats' only irritate already frustrated fellow passengers."
- POV also answers: "What do we need to change? Where and with whom precisely will we apply leverage to shift the system into a desirable alternative pattern?"

Ideation & "How Might We...?" (HMW)

- Ideation = the creative act of generating ideas - both a stance/orientation and a set of enabling strategies; answers "How will we bring about the change? How will we intervene?"
- HMW questions reframe the POV as provocations that open up (rather than foreclose) solution space.

HMW heuristics (from the worked airport example)

- Amp up the good: "HMW use the kids' energy to entertain fellow passengers?"
- Remove the bad: "HMW separate the kids from fellow passengers?"
- Explore the opposite: "HMW make the wait the most exciting part of the trip?"
- Question an assumption: "HMW entirely remove the wait time at the airport?"
- Go after adjectives: "HMW make the rush refreshing instead of harrying?"
- ID unexpected resources: "HMW leverage free time of fellow passengers to share the load?"
- Create an analogy from need or context: "HMW make the airport like a spa? Like a playground?"
- Play POV against the challenge: "HMW make the airport a place kids want to go?"
- Change a status quo: "HMW make playful, loud kids less annoying?"
- Break POV into pieces: "HMW entertain kids? HMW slow a mom down? HMW mollify delayed passengers?"

Closing exercise: apply the same heuristics to a new POV - "A toddler's parents, trying to avoid potty training accidents that are inconvenient for the parents and discouraging to the toddler, need to help their child be more patient on the potty because accidents commonly occur after the toddler quickly bores and leaves the potty too soon."